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Conducting built-in self-test of memory macro

Abstract

Performing a built-in self-test (BIST) on a memory macro includes generating a plurality of input vectors such that at least one input vector of the plurality of input vectors is transmitted to the memory macro in each of a plurality of cycles, receiving in each of the plurality of cycles, an output data from the memory macro. The output data is generated by the memory macro in response to processing the at least one input vector. The BIST also includes comparing the output data in each of the plurality of cycles with a signature value and determining whether the memory macro is normal or faulty based upon the comparison.

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Background/Summary

CROSS-REFERENCE TO RELATED PATENT APPLICATIONS (1) This application is a continuation of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 17/470,838, filed Sep. 9, 2021, which is a non-provisional application of U.S. Provisional Application No. 63/147,988, filed Feb. 10, 2021, which are incorporated herein by reference in their entireties for all purposes.

BACKGROUND

(1) The present disclosure relates generally to memory systems, and particularly to performing built-in self-tests in memory systems.

(2) Deep learning algorithms evaluate data sets against predefined importance parameters or weights of several attributes. Such evaluation may be characterized by an additive weighting method that requires a large number of Multiply-and-Accumulate (MAC) operations. In some embodiments, discreet logic circuits may be used to implement the MAC operations. However, such logic circuits require high energy (e.g., power), large circuit implementation, and performance may be limited. Compute in Memory (CIM) is a promising energy efficient solution for deep learning applications. A CIM is configured to perform the MAC operations in addition to storing the data sets and the weights. A CIM is also easy to integrate into a memory system. However, challenges exist in performing Built-In Self-Test (BIST) in CIM.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

(1) Aspects of the present disclosure are best understood from the following detailed description when read with the accompanying figures. It is noted that, in accordance with the standard practice in the industry, various features are not drawn to scale. In fact, the dimensions of the various features may be arbitrarily increased or reduced for clarity of discussion.

(2) FIG. 1 is an example block diagram of a computing system configured to perform a Built-In Self-Test (BIST) in a Compute in Memory (CIM) macro, in accordance with some embodiments of the present disclosure.

(3) FIG. 2 is an example block diagram of a BIST circuit of the computing system of FIG. 1 for implementing a BIST on the CIM macro, in accordance with some embodiments of the present disclosure.

(4) FIG. 3 is an example block diagram showing additional details of the BIST implementation by the BIST circuit of FIG. 2, in accordance with some embodiments of the present disclosure.

(5) FIG. 4 is an example flowchart outlining operations of a process performed by the BIST circuit of FIG. 2 for implementing a broadside input pattern BIST methodology on the CIM macro, in accordance with some embodiments of the present disclosure.

(6) FIG. 5 is an example block diagram showing an initial weight register and an active weight register used by the BIST circuit of FIG. 2 for generating weights for implementing the BIST on the CIM macro, in accordance with some embodiments of the present disclosure.

(7) FIG. 6 is an example flowchart outlining operations of a process performed by the BIST circuit of FIG. 2 for implementing a weight as memory background BIST methodology on the CIM macro, in accordance with some embodiments of the present disclosure.

- (8) FIG. 7 is an example flowchart outlining operations of a process performed by the BIST circuit of FIG. 2 for implementing a multiple background weights BIST methodology on the CIM macro, in accordance with some embodiments of the present disclosure.
- (9) FIG. 8 is an example block diagram of a lossless compression BIST methodology, in accordance with some embodiments of the present disclosure.
- (10) FIG. 9 is an example flowchart outlining operations of a process performed by the BIST circuit of FIG. 2 and the CIM macro for implementing the lossless compression BIST methodology of FIG. 8, in accordance with some embodiments of the present disclosure.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

- (11) The following disclosure provides many different embodiments, or examples, for implementing different features of the provided subject matter. Specific examples of components and arrangements are described below to simplify the present disclosure. These are, of course, merely examples and are not intended to be limiting. For example, the formation of a first feature over or on a second feature in the description that follows may include embodiments in which the first and second features are formed in direct contact and may also include embodiments in which additional features may be formed between the first and second features, such that the first and second features may not be in direct contact. In addition, the present disclosure may repeat reference numerals and/or letters in the various examples. This repetition is for the purpose of simplicity and clarity and does not in itself dictate a relationship between the various embodiments and/or configurations discussed.
- (12) Further, spatially relative terms, such as “beneath,” “below,” “lower,” “above,” “upper” and the like, may be used herein for ease of description to describe one element or feature's relationship to another element(s) or feature(s) as illustrated in the figures. The spatially relative terms are intended to encompass different orientations of the device in use or operation in addition to the orientation depicted in the figures. The apparatus may be otherwise oriented (rotated 90 degrees or at other orientations) and the spatially relative descriptors used herein may likewise be interpreted accordingly.
- (13) Referring now to FIG. 1, an example block diagram of a computing system **100** is shown, in accordance with some embodiments of the disclosure. The computing system **100** may be used for implementing a Built In Self-Test (BIST) of a memory macro (e.g., a Compute In Memory (CIM) macro). The computing system **100** includes a host device **105** associated with a memory device **110**. The host device **105** may be configured to receive input from one or more input devices **115** and provide output to one or more output devices **120**. The host device **105** may be configured to communicate with the memory device **110**, the input devices **115**, and the output devices **120** via appropriate interfaces **125A**, **125B**, and **125C**, respectively. The computing system **100** may be implemented in a variety of computing devices such as computers (e.g., desktop, laptop, servers, data centers, etc.), tablets, personal digital assistants, mobile devices, other handheld or portable devices, or any other computing unit suitable for performing BIST using the host device **105**.
- (14) The input devices **115** may include any of a variety of input technologies such as a keyboard, stylus, touch screen, mouse, track ball, keypad, microphone, voice recognition, motion recognition, remote controllers, input ports, one or more buttons, dials, joysticks, and any other input peripheral that is associated with the host device **105** and that allows an external source, such as a user, to enter information (e.g., data) into the host device and send instructions to the host device. Similarly, the output devices **120** may include a variety of output technologies such as external memories, printers, speakers, displays, microphones, light emitting diodes, headphones, video devices, and any other output peripherals that are configured to receive information (e.g., data) from the host device **105**. The “data” that is either input into the host device **105** and/or output from the host device may include any of a variety of textual data, circuit data, signal data, semiconductor device data, graphical data, configuration data, combinations thereof, or other types of analog and/or digital data that is suitable for processing using the computing system **100**.

(15) The host device **105** includes or is associated with one or more processing units/processors, such as Central Processing Unit (“CPU”) cores **130A-130N**. The CPU cores **130A-130N** may be implemented as an Application Specific Integrated Circuit (“ASIC”), Field Programmable Gate Array (“FPGA”), or any other type of processing technology. Each of the CPU cores **130A-130N** may be configured to execute instructions for running one or more applications of the host device **105**. In some embodiments, the instructions and data needed to run the one or more applications may be stored within the memory device **110**. The host device **105** may also be configured to store the results of running the one or more applications within the memory device **110**. Thus, the host device **105** may be configured to request the memory device **110** to perform a variety of operations. For example, the host device **105** may request the memory device **110** to read data, write data, update or delete data, perform BIST, and/or perform management or other operations.

(16) One application that the host device **105** may be configured to run may be a BIST application **135**. The BIST application **135** may be used in association with a BIST circuit **140** to test one or more memories of the memory device **110**. Specifically, the BIST application **135** and the BIST circuit **140** may be used to identify faults or problems in the one or more memories of the memory device **110** that may cause those one or more memories to malfunction. The BIST application **135** and the BIST circuit **140** are discussed in greater detail below. In some embodiments, the instructions needed to execute or run the BIST application **135** and the BIST circuit **140** may be stored within the memory device **110**. The BIST application **135** may be executed by one or more of the CPU cores **130A-130N** using the instructions associated with the BIST application from the memory device **110**. In some embodiments, the BIST application **135** may be used to enter configuration data into the BIST circuit **140**, as well as generate various signals to perform BIST on the memory device **110**.

(17) Referring still to FIG. 1, the memory device **110** includes a memory controller **145** that is configured to read data from or write data to a memory array **150**. In some embodiments, the memory array **150** may include a variety of volatile and/or non-volatile memories. For example, in some embodiments, the memory array **150** may include NAND flash memory cores, NOR flash memory cores, Static Random Access Memory (SRAM) cores, Dynamic Random Access Memory (DRAM) cores, Magnetoresistive Random Access Memory (MRAM) cores, Phase Change Memory (PCM) cores, Resistive Random Access Memory (ReRAM) cores, 3D XPoint memory cores, ferroelectric random-access memory (FeRAM) cores, and other types of memory cores that are suitable for being tested using BIST. Generally speaking, the memory array **150** may include any of a variety of Random Access Memory (RAM), Read-Only Memory (ROM), Programmable ROM (PROM), Erasable PROM (EPROM), Electrically EPROM (EEPROM), hard disk drives, flash drives, memory tapes, optical drives, cloud memory, or any combination of primary and/or secondary memory that is suitable for the functions described herein. In some embodiments, the memory array **150** may be configured as, or be part of, an embedded memory of a system on chip (SOC) integrated circuit device.

(18) The memories within the memory array **150** may be individually and independently controlled by the memory controller **145**. In other words, the memory controller **145** may be configured to communicate with each memory within the memory array **150** individually and independently. By communicating with the memory array **150**, the memory controller **145** may be configured to read data from or write data to the memory array in response to instructions received from the host device **105**. Although shown as being part of the memory device **110**, in some embodiments, the memory controller **145** may be part of the host device **105** or part of another component of the computing system **100** and associated with the memory device. The memory controller **145** may be implemented as a logic circuit in either software, hardware, firmware, or combination thereof to perform the functions described herein.

(19) It is to be understood that only some components of the computing system **100** are shown and described in FIG. 1. However, the computing system **100** may include other components such as

various batteries and power sources, networking interfaces, routers, switches, external memory systems, controllers, etc. Generally speaking, the computing system **100** may include any of a variety of hardware, software, and/or firmware components that are needed or considered desirable in performing the functions described herein. Similarly, the host device **105**, the input devices **115**, the output devices **120**, and the memory device **110** including the memory controller **145** and the memory array **150** may each include other hardware, software, and/or firmware components that are considered necessary or desirable in performing the functions described herein.

(20) Turning to FIG. 2, an example block diagram of the BIST circuit **140** is shown, in accordance with some embodiments of the present disclosure. The BIST circuit **140** is shown connected to a CIM macro **155** for performing a BIST on the CIM macro. The CIM macro **155** may be part of the memory array **150**. Although not shown, the CIM macro **155** may include a plurality of memory cells for storing data. In some embodiments, the CIM macro **155** may also include related peripheral circuitry (e.g., circuitry for reading data from the memory cell, writing data into the memory cells, etc.) The plurality of memory cells may be part of a memory address space of the CIM macro **155**. The CIM macro **155** may also be configured to perform computations in addition to storing data. For example, in some embodiments, the CIM macro **155** may be configured to perform Multiply-and-Accumulate (MAC) operations on the data stored therein.

(21) Thus, in some embodiments, the CIM macro **155** may be configured to perform two main functions: (a) a memory function for storing data used in the computations of the MAC operations; and (b) a compute function for performing the MAC operations on the stored data. In some embodiments, the CIM macro **155** may implement the MAC operation of the compute function as follows:

$$(22) Q_CIM[j] = \text{.Math.}_{i=0}^M X[i] \text{.Math. } W[i,j]$$

(23) In the formula above, M is a total number of attributes (e.g., number of rows in the memory address space of the CIM macro **155**), $Q_CIM[j]$ is the accumulated result for the j.sup.th cycle, $X[i]$ is the input data, and $W[i, j]$ is the weight being applied to the input data in the j.sup.th cycle. In some embodiments, the CIM macro **155** may implement the MAC operations using analog circuits including a transistor level implementation. The analog circuits may be embedded inside the CIM macro **155**. In other embodiments, the CIM macro **155** may implement the MAC operations using digital circuits. In some embodiments, the digital circuits may include discreet logic circuits that are outside, and associated with, the CIM macro **155** for performing the MAC operations. In other embodiments, the digital circuits may include logic circuits that are embedded into the CIM macro **155**. In yet other embodiments, the CIM macro **155** may implement the MAC operations using a combination of analog and digital circuits.

(24) Further, in some embodiments, the analog circuit implementation of the MAC operation may be tested using analog functional test methods. In other embodiments, the analog circuit implementation may be tested using the BIST circuit **140**. The discreet logic circuit implementation that is outside, and associated with, the CIM macro **155** may be tested separately from the CIM macro. However, inventors have found no testing methods for CIM macros (e.g., the CIM macro **155**) that have the logic circuits for the MAC implementation embedded therein. The BIST circuit **140** may be used to perform BIST on the CIM macro **155** that have the MAC operation functionality embedded therein. A BIST may be used by the CIM macro **155** to test itself with high reliability and accuracy. To perform the BIST on the CIM macro **155**, the BIST circuit **140** may be part of the memory device (e.g., the memory device **110**) associated with the CIM macro. Thus, in some embodiments, the BIST circuit **140** and the CIM macro **155** may be configured as an SOC.

(25) Although the present disclosure is described in terms of testing the CIM macro **155**, it is to be understood that the present disclosure may be used to perform BIST using the BIST circuit **140** on any suitable memory macro or memory device.

(26) The BIST circuit **140** may be configured to generate data for performing BIST on the CIM macro **155**. The data may include input data and weight data. The BIST circuit **140** may also be

configured to receive output data from the CIM macro **155**. The output data may be the result of the MAC operations on the input data and the weight data using the equation discussed above. The BIST circuit **140** may additionally be configured to compare the output data with expected data (e.g., a signature value) to determine if the CIM macro **155** is normal or faulty. The CIM macro **155** may be considered “normal” if the CIM macro performs the MAC operations accurately. The CIM macro **155** may be considered “faulty” if the CIM macro produces inaccurate MAC operation results.

(27) To generate the input data, the BIST circuit **140** may include a data generator **160**. The data generator **160** may be configured to generate deterministic, random, or pseudo random input vectors for testing the CIM macro **155**. A deterministic input data may include an input vector having a known or specific value. A random or pseudorandom input data may include a randomly or pseudo-randomly generated input vector. Each input vector may be of a designated bit width. In some embodiments, the bit width of the input vector may be dependent upon the configuration of the CIM macro **155**. For example, in some embodiments, the data generator **160** may be configured to generate input vectors of 64 bits if the CIM macro **155** is configured to handle data of 64 bits. In other embodiments, each input vector may be 32 bits, 72 bits, 128 bits, or of any other bit width depending upon the configuration of the CIM macro **155**.

(28) In some embodiments, the data generator **160** may be configured to generate the input vectors using a linear feedback shift register, a series of automated circuits, or any other suitable mechanism. Although not shown, the data generator **160** may be configured as hardware, software, firmware, or a combination thereof. In some embodiments, the data generator **160** may generate the input vectors based upon an input **165** received from a BIST Finite State Machine (FSM) **170**. In some embodiments, the BIST FSM **170** may generate the input **165** based upon a configuration value. In some embodiments, the configuration value may include the input vector value that is to be generated by the data generator **160**. In some embodiments, the configuration value may indicate an initial input vector value for the data generator **160** to generate an input vector. The configuration value may also include an increment value or shift value to indicate to the data generator **160** how to generate additional input vectors from the initial input vector value. For example, in some embodiments, the configuration value may indicate an increment value of 1. The data generator **160** may then increment the initial input vector value by 1 to obtain a first input vector value, increment the first input vector value by 1 to obtain a second input vector value, and so on. Thus, the data generator **160** may be configured to generate the input vectors in any suitable way.)

(29) The data generator **160** may transmit the generated input vector into a multiplexer **175** as input **180**. The multiplexer **175** may also receive an input **185**. The input **185** may be a functional input vector used during normal operation (e.g., when BIST is not being performed) of the CIM macro **155**. Based upon an enable signal **190**, the multiplexer **175** may select either the input **180** or the input **185** as output **195**. The output **195** may be input into the CIM macro **155** for a MAC operation. In some embodiments, the output **195** may be stored (e.g., into an input register) into the CIM macro **155**. The enable signal **190** may be generated by the BIST circuit **140** (e.g., by the BIST FSM **170**). If the enable signal **190** indicates a BIST mode, the multiplexer **175** selects the input **180** as the output **195** and if the enable signal indicates a functional mode (e.g., normal operation), the multiplexer selects the input **185** as the output. Although the multiplexer **175** is shown separate from the CIM macro **155**, in some embodiments, the multiplexer may be part of the CIM macro. For example, in some embodiments, the multiplexer **175** may be part of the peripheral circuitry of the CIM macro **155**. In other embodiments, the multiplexer **175** may be part of the BIST circuit **140** or any other component associated with the BIST circuit and the CIM macro **155**.

(30) The BIST circuit **140** may also include a weight generator **200**. Although not shown, the weight generator **200** may be configured as hardware, software, firmware, or a combination thereof. The weight generator **200** may generate one or more weights to be applied to the input

vector generated by the data generator **160**. In some embodiments, the weight generator **200** may generate the weights based upon an input **205** received from the BIST FSM **170**. The weight generator **200** may also receive an input **210** from an address generator **215** to identify the memory addresses of the CIM macro **155** for which the weights are to be generated. Weight generation is discussed in greater detail below. The weights generated by the weight generator **200** are input into a multiplexer **220** as input **225**.

(31) The multiplexer **220** may also receive a functional weight input **230** (e.g., used during normal operation of the CIM macro **155**). Based upon the enable signal **190**, the multiplexer **220** may select either the input **225** or the functional weight input **230** as output **235**, which is input into the CIM macro **155**. The output **235** may be stored within a memory address space of the CIM macro **155**. If the enable signal **190** indicates a BIST mode, the multiplexer **220** selects the input **225** as the output **235** and if the enable signal indicates a functional mode (e.g., normal operation), the multiplexer selects the functional weight input **230** as the output. Similar to the multiplexer **175**, the multiplexer **220** may be part of the CIM macro **155**, the BIST circuit **140**, or any other component associated with the BIST circuit or the CIM macro.

(32) The address generator **215** may be configured to generate memory addresses where the weights generated by the weight generator **200** are to be stored in the CIM macro **155**. The address generator **215** may generate the memory addresses in response to an input **240** received from the BIST FSM **170**. The input **240** may indicate the memory addresses or address range of the CIM macro **155** based on which the address generator **215** generates the addresses. In some embodiments, the address generator **215** may be configured to generate write addresses for storing the input vectors, write addresses for storing the weights, read addresses for reading the stored input vectors and weights for performing the MAC operations, and/or write addresses for storing the output data before transmission back to the BIST circuit **140**. In some embodiments, the address generator **215** may be configured as a linear feedback shift register or use other types of logic circuits or mechanisms to generate the addresses. The address generator **215** may input the generated memory addresses into a multiplexer **245** as input **250**. The multiplexer **245** may also receive a functional memory address input **255** (e.g., used during normal operation of the CIM macro **155**). Based upon the enable signal **190**, the multiplexer **245** may select either the input **250** or the input **255** as output **260**, which is input into the CIM macro **155**. If the enable signal **190** indicates a BIST mode, the multiplexer **245** selects the input **250** as the output **260** and if the enable signal indicates a functional mode (e.g., normal operation), the multiplexer selects the input **255** as the output. In some embodiments, the multiplexer **245** may be part of the CIM macro **155**, the BIST circuit **140**, or any other component associated with the BIST circuit and/or the CIM macro.

(33) The BIST circuit **140** may also include a configuration register **265**. The configuration register **265** may be used to receive configuration values from a user to configure or initialize the BIST. For example, in some embodiments, the configuration register **265** may receive an input from a user (e.g., via the BIST application **135**) indicating which BIST methodology to apply. For example, in some embodiments, the BIST methodology may be a broadside input pattern BIST methodology, a multiple background weights BIST methodology, a weight as memory background BIST methodology, or a lossless compression BIST methodology. Each of these BIST methodologies is explained in greater detail below. The BIST methodology may be indicative of the input data to be used, the weights to be used, the address range to be used, the number of cycles in the BIST, the signature value in each cycle, and any other details that may be needed or desired in performing the BIST for that BIST methodology. The configuration values may be input from the configuration register **265** into the BIST FSM **170**, as indicated by arrow **270**. Based upon the configuration values, the BIST FSM **170** may generate one or more inputs (e.g., the input **165**, **205**, **240**, etc.) for controlling the operation of the other components (e.g., data generator **160**, the weight generator **200**, the address generator **215**, etc.) of the BIST circuit **140**.

(34) The BIST FSM **170** may also control the operation of a comparator **275** and a register **280**.

Upon receiving the various BIST inputs (e.g., the input vector and the weights), the CIM macro **155** may perform the compute function using the equation discussed above. The result of that computation may be output from the CIM macro **155** as output **285**. The output **285** may be input into the register **280**, as well as output for user review, as indicated by arrow **290**. The output **285** may be stored within the register **280** based upon a control signal **295** received from the BIST FSM **170**. The output **285** may also be input from the register **280** into the comparator **275**. The comparator **275** may compare the output **285** with a signature value received from the BIST FSM **170** via a signature signal **300**.

(35) The signature value may indicate the expected value of the computation performed by the CIM macro **155** for the input vector and weights input into the CIM macro in the BIST mode. An output **305** of the comparator **275** may indicate whether the output **285** matches the signature value. In some embodiments, the output **305** may be input into the BIST FSM **170**, which in some embodiments, may send that output to the configuration register **265**. The user may read the output **305** from the configuration register **265** to determine if the CIM macro **155** is normal or faulty. In some embodiments, the BIST FSM **170** may also store the output **305** into the register **280** or another register.

(36) In some embodiments, the BIST may be performed over a plurality of cycles. Each of the plurality of cycles may include applying an input vector and weights into the CIM macro **155** from the BIST circuit **140**, the CIM macro performing the MAC operations on the input vector and the weights and sending the output **285** back to the BIST circuit **140**. In some embodiments, the output **305** of the comparison of the output **285** with the signature value may be stored in the register **280**, and the determination of whether the CIM macro **155** is faulty or normal may be made at the end of the plurality of cycles based upon an analysis of the output **305** of each of the plurality of cycles. In some embodiments, the number of the plurality of cycles that are used may be a large number to provide greater fault coverage and fault diagnosis of the CIM macro **155**. For example, in some embodiments, the number of the plurality of cycles may be greater than the number of cycles during an actual functioning of the CIM macro **155**. Further, in some embodiments, the same BIST methodology may be implemented in each of the plurality of cycles. In other embodiments, a combination of methodologies may be used in the plurality of cycles.

(37) The BIST FSM **170**, as indicated above, may be configured to control the operation of the BIST circuit **140**. Based upon the configuration values received from the configuration register **265**, the BIST FSM **170** may generate the input **165** to the data generator **160** to generate one or more input vectors. Similarly, based upon the configuration values, the BIST FSM **170** may generate the input **205** to the weight generator **200** to generate the weights, as well as the input **240** to the address generator **215** to generate the addresses. The BIST FSM **170** may also generate a control signal **310** that may serve as a write enable signal to allow the data being sent by the BIST circuit **140** to be written into the CIM macro **155**. Specifically, the control signal **310** may be input into a multiplexer **315**.

(38) The multiplexer **315** may also receive an input **320**. Based upon the enable signal **190**, the multiplexer **315** may select either the control signal **310** or the input **320** as output **325**, which is input into the CIM macro **155**. The input **320** may be a control signal (e.g., write enable) used for storing data within the CIM macro **155** during normal operation. Thus, the input **320** may be considered a functional control signal. If the enable signal **190** indicates a BIST mode, the multiplexer **315** selects the control signal **310** as the output **325** and writes the data (e.g., input vector and weights) being sent by the BIST circuit **140** to the CIM macro **155**. If the enable signal **190** indicates a functional mode (e.g., normal operation), the multiplexer **315** selects the input **320** as the output **325** and writes the functional data (e.g., the functional input vector and functional weights) into the CIM macro **155**. In some embodiments, the multiplexer **315** may be part of the CIM macro **155**, the BIST circuit **140**, or any other component associated with the BIST circuit and/or the CIM macro.

(39) It is to be understood that only some components of the BIST circuit **140** are shown and described herein. Nevertheless, the BIST circuit **140** may include other or additional components that may be needed or considered desirable to have in performing the functions described herein. Further, the data generator **160**, the BIST FSM **170**, the weight generator **200**, the address generator **215**, the configuration register **265**, the comparator **275**, and the register **280** may be configured as software, hardware, firmware, or combination thereof, and may be sized as needed. Similarly, the multiplexers **175**, **245**, **315**, and **220** may be configured in any suitable way.

(40) Turning now to FIG. 3, an example block diagram showing additional details of BIST are shown, in accordance with some embodiments of the present disclosure. Specifically, FIG. 3 shows the CIM macro **155** and the data generator **160** of the BIST circuit **140**. The CIM macro **155** has a memory address space **330** having a plurality of memory addresses (e.g., memory address [1:n]). Each memory address in the memory address space **330** may be considered a row and may be configured to store one or more weight values. In some embodiments, each memory address of the memory address space **330** may be configured to store a different weight value. In some embodiments, at least some of the memory addresses in the memory address space **330** may be configured to store a same weight value. The weight values stored in the memory address space **330** may be unsigned values or signed values (e.g., 2's complements of the unsigned values). Generation of the weight values is discussed below.

(41) Further, in some embodiments, the input vectors that are applied to the weight values stored in the memory address space **330** may be of a designated bit width, D. The input vector of bit width, D, may be applied to the weight(s) stored in each row of the memory address space **330** using the equation discussed above to perform the MAC operations. In some embodiments, for an input vector of a bit width, D, the data generator **160** may generate an input vector of size D (e.g., XIN[1:D]). The XIN[1:D] bits of the input vector may be applied to the weight values stored in each row of the memory address space **330**, as shown by arrow **335**. Thus, in some embodiments, for each row of the memory address space **330**, the CIM macro **155** may compute a product between the input vector and the weights stored in that row to obtain a partial product. The partial product from each row of the memory address space **330** may then be added to generate the output **285** for a cycle.

(42) Turning now to FIG. 4, an example flowchart outlining operations of a process **340** for implementing a broadside input pattern BIST methodology is shown, in accordance with some embodiments of the present disclosure. The process **340** may be implemented by the BIST circuit **140**. To implement the broadside input pattern BIST methodology, at operation **345**, the BIST circuit **140** is initialized or configured. Specifically, at the operation **345**, a user may input configuration values into the configuration register **265**. The configuration values may include the data pattern to be generated for each cycle, a number of cycles, an expected signature value for each cycle, an initial weight register value, memory addresses, and any other input that may be needed or considered desirable to have in implementing the process **340**. In each cycle, the data generator **160** may generate at least one input vector. Thus, in some embodiments, each cycle of the plurality of cycles may be based on a different input vector.

(43) The configuration values input into the configuration register **265** may be transmitted to the BIST FSM **170**, which may then generate the inputs **165**, **240**, **205**, **310**, **295**, and **300**, as discussed above. Upon receiving the input **165**, the data generator **160** generates an input vector at operation **350** for a current cycle of a plurality of cycles. The input **165** may indicate the data pattern based on which the data generator **160** is to generate the input vector. In some embodiments, to transmit (and possibly store) the input vector into the CIM macro **155** (e.g., into an input register), the BIST FSM **170** may generate the enable signal **190** that allows the multiplexer **175** to select the input **180** from the data generator **160** of the BIST circuit **140**. The BIST FSM **170** may also generate the control signal **310** that allows the multiplexer **315** to select the control signal from the BIST circuit and facilitate the transmission and/or writing of the input vector into the CIM macro **155**.

(44) At operation **355**, weights are generated and stored within the memory address space **330** of the CIM macro **155**. Although the generation of the input vector is described as occurring before the generation of the weights, in some embodiments, the generation of the weights may occur before the generation of the input vector, or both operations may occur in parallel. In some embodiments, the same weight values may be used in each of the plurality of cycles. In other embodiments, different weight values may be used in at least some of the plurality of cycles. In some embodiments, the weight values may be stored in the CIM macro **155** at the addresses provided by the address generator **215**. To write the weight values into the CIM macro **155**, the enable signal **190** allows the multiplexer **220** to select the weight values from the BIST circuit **140** as the output **235**, which may be written to the addresses selected by the address generator **215**.

(45) Upon sending the input vector and the weight values into the CIM macro **155**, at operation **360**, the BIST circuit **140** receives the output data from the CIM macro. Specifically, the CIM macro performs a MAC operation on the input vector of the operation **350** and the weight values of the operation **355**. More specifically, the weight value stored at each memory address of the memory address space **330** is multiplied by the input vector to obtain a partial product for each memory address. The various partial products are then summed to obtain the output data. Thus, each cycle in the plurality of cycles may generate one output data. The output data (e.g., the output **285**) may be received and stored into the register **280** and also provided to the comparator **275**.

(46) At operation **365**, the comparator **275** compares the output data from the operation **360** with the signature value received as a configuration value at the operation **345**. The comparison may indicate whether the output data from the operation **360** matches the signature value or does not match the signature value. In some embodiments, the result (e.g., match or no match) of the comparison is sent to the BIST FSM **170** at operation **370**, which may send the result to the register **280** for storing. At operation **375**, the BIST FSM **170** determines if additional cycles are remaining in the BIST. If more cycles are remaining, the process **340** loops back to the operation **345** where a new input vector is generated and transmitted to the CIM macro. In some embodiments, new weights may also be generated at the operation **355**. In other embodiments, the same weights may be used. The operations **345-370** may be repeated for each cycle.

(47) Upon completing all the plurality of cycles, at operation **380**, the BIST FSM **170** analyzes all the stored results from the operation **370**. If the results in all of the cycles indicate a match with their respective signature values, the process **340** proceeds to operation **385** where the BIST FSM **170** declares the CIM macro **155** to be normal. On the other hand, if at least one of the results do not match their respective signature value, the process **340** proceeds to operation **390** where the BIST FSM **170** declares the CIM macro **155** to be faulty. Thus, in some embodiments, the CIM macro **155** is considered normal only upon the output data from each of the plurality of cycles matching the signature value of that cycle. In some embodiments, instead of passing the CIM macro **155** only upon the output data from each cycle of the plurality of cycles matching their respective signature values, in some embodiments, the CIM macro may be considered normal if the number of cycles in which there is a match is above a predefined threshold. For example, in some embodiments, the BIST FSM **170** may consider the CIM macro **155** to be normal if X % of the cycles have output data that match their respective signature values. Thus, the benchmark for finding the CIM macro **155** to be normal or faulty may be predefined and provided as a configuration value and stored within the BIST FSM **170**. In some embodiments, the determination of whether the CIM macro **155** is normal or faulty may be written into the configuration register **265** from which a user may read and determine the status of the CIM macro.

(48) Referring now to FIG. 5, an example diagram explaining weight value generation is shown, in accordance with some embodiments of the present disclosure. The weight values are generated by the weight generator **200** described with reference to FIG. 2. The weight generator **200** may generate the weight values based on an initial weight register value, an increment value, and the write address. In some embodiments, the initial weight register value, the increment value, and the

write addresses may be provided as a configuration value within the configuration register **265**. From the configuration register **265** described with reference to FIG. **2**, these configuration values may be transmitted to the BIST FSM **170**, which may then generate the inputs **205** and **240**. Based on the input **240**, the address generator **215** may generate the write addresses and send the write addresses to the weight generator **200** as the input **210**. The weight generator **200**, upon receiving the input **205** and the input **210** from the address generator **215** may generate weight values for each memory address in the memory address space **330** of the CIM macro **155**.

(49) In some embodiments, the weight generator **200** may use two registers to generate the weight values: an initial weight register **395** and an active weight register **400**. In some embodiments, the weight generator **200** may receive the initial weight register value via the input **205**. The weight generator **200** may write the initial weight register value in the initial weight register **395** and designate that value for an initial write address as determined by the input **210**. For example, and as shown in FIG. **5**, the initial weight register **395** has been initialized with the value 0010. It is to be understood that the values in FIG. **5** are only an example and not intended to be limiting in any way.

(50) Based on the value in the initial weight register **395**, the weight generator **200** may populate the active weight register **400** as follows:

awr.sub.0  custom character *iwr*

awr.sub.i+1  custom character *F(awr.sub.i+C,A)*

(51) In the function above, *awn* indicates a row of the active weight register **400**, *C* indicates the increment value, and *A* indicates the write address where the *awr.sub.i+1* value is to be written.

(52) Thus, the active weight register **400** may be initialized with the value of the initial weight register **395** to be written in the memory address indicated in the initial write address. For example, a first row **405** of the active weight register **400** is shown as being initialized with the initial weight register value to be written in the initial write address. Based on the value in the first row **405**, the weight value for a second row **410** of the active weight register **400** is determined. For example, if the increment value is 1, the weight value in the first row **405** is incremented by 1 to obtain the value of 0011 shown in the second row **410** and designated to be written in the next memory address. Similarly, the weight value in a third row **415** of the active weight register **400** may be determined by incrementing the weight value in the second row **410** by 1, and the weight value in a fourth row **420** of the active weight register may be determined by incrementing the weight value in the third row by 1.

(53) Although the active weight register **400** is shown as having only four rows, with each row corresponding to a particular memory address, the number of rows in the active weight register may be dependent upon the number of memory addresses in the memory address space **330** for which the weight values are being generated (e.g., number of memory addresses in the memory address space **330**). For example, if the memory address space **330** has 64 memory addresses, the active weight register **400** may include 64 rows—one row for each memory address. Further, although the increment value used in the example above is 1, other increment values may be used in other embodiments.

(54) The weight values in the active weight register **400** may be written into the CIM macro **155**. For example, the weight value in the first row **405** of the active weight register **400** may be written into a first memory address of the memory address space **330** of the CIM macro **155**. Similarly, the weight value in the second row **410** may be written into a second memory address, and so on. Thus, in some embodiments, the active weight register may generate unique weight values for each memory address of the memory address space **330**.

(55) Turning to FIG. **6**, an example flowchart outlining operations of a process **425** is shown, in accordance with some embodiments of the present disclosure. The process **425** may be used to implement a weight as memory background BIST methodology for performing BIST on the CIM macro **155**. At operation **430**, the BIST circuit **140** is initialized by writing configuration values in

the configuration register **265** (see FIG. 2). The configuration values may include the data pattern to be generated for each cycle, a number of cycles, an expected signature value for each cycle, an initial weight register value for each cycle, memory addresses, and any other input that may be needed or considered desirable to have in implementing the process **425**. At operation **435**, the data generator **160** generates an input vector and stores that input vector (e.g., in an input register) in the CIM macro **155**, as discussed above with respect to FIGS. 3 and 4. In some embodiments, the same input vector may be used for each cycle and the weight values may be varied in each cycle. In other embodiments, both the input vector and the weight values may be varied in at least some cycles.

(56) At operation **440**, the weight generator **200** initializes the active weight register **400** with the value of the initial weight register **395**. In some embodiments, the weight generator **200** may write each value in the active weight register **400** into the CIM macro **155** as the weight value is generated. In other embodiments, the weight generator **200** may generate all the weight values before writing them all together into the CIM macro **155**. At operation **445**, the weight generator **200** computes the remaining weight values in the active weight register **400**, as discussed above in FIG. 5. At operation **450**, the weight generator **200** writes the weight values into the designated memory addresses of the CIM macro **155**.

(57) Specifically, the weight generator **200** sends the weight values to the multiplexer **220**. The BIST FSM **170** generates the enable signal **190** and the control signal **310** to allow the multiplexer **220** to select the input **225** for writing the weight values into the CIM macro **155**. Upon writing the input vector and the weight values into the CIM macro **155**, at operation **455**, the output data is received from the CIM macro. The operation **455** is similar to operation **360**, and therefore, not described again. Similarly, operations **460-485** are similar to operations **365-390**, and therefore, not described again. For example, at the operation **460**, the comparator **275** compares the output data received at the operation **455** with the signature value for that cycle and the result (e.g., match, no match) of the comparison is stored in the register **280** at the operation **465**. If, at the operation **470**, the BIST FSM **170** determines that there are additional cycles of BIST to be performed, the process **425** loops back to the operation **440** if the same input vector is to be used to generate new weight values for the next cycle, or to the operation **435** if a different input vector and new weight values are to be used in the next cycle.

(58) Upon completing all cycles, the BIST FSM **170** determines if all (or a threshold number of) cycles have results that match with their respective signature values at the operation **475** and determines whether the CIM macro **155** is normal at the operation **480** or faulty at the operation **485**, as discussed above.

(59) Referring now to FIG. 7, an example flowchart outlining operations of a process **490** is shown, in accordance with some embodiments of the present disclosure. The process **490** may be used to implement a multiple background weights BIST methodology by the BIST circuit **140**. The multiple background weights BIST methodology may be particularly beneficial to use when faults in specific bits of a particular memory address are desired to be found. For example, in some embodiments, the processes of FIGS. 4 and 6 may be used to identify a faulty memory address. The process **490** may then be used to identify the exact bit of the faulty memory address that is faulty. Thus, the process **490** may afford better fault diagnosis. For example, in some embodiments, upon determining a faulty memory address, the BIST circuit **140** may write zero value weights to all memory addresses except for the faulty memory address. The weight value written into the faulty memory address may be changed in each cycle (e.g., by one bit) until the faulty bit (or bits) is (are) identified.

(60) Thus, at operation **495**, the BIST circuit **140** is initialized by writing configuration values in the configuration register **265**. For example, in some embodiments, the configuration values may include the faulty memory address, weight values (or at least the initial weight register value) for the faulty memory address, number of cycles, signature value for each cycle, data pattern, and any other information that may be needed or considered desirable. The number of cycles when trying to

identify one or more faulty bits may correspond to the number of bits in the faulty memory address. At operation **500**, the data generator **160** generates an input vector and stores that input vector (e.g., into an input register) into the CIM macro **155**, as discussed above. In some embodiments, the same input vector may be used in each cycle. In other embodiments, at least some of the cycles may use a different input vector. At operation **505**, the weight generator **200** writes weight values of zeroes to all memory address locations other than the faulty memory address location.

(61) Specifically, to generate the weight values, the address generator **215** generates the memory addresses of the CIM macro **155** where the zero weight values are to be written. The weight generator **200** may populate the rows of the active weight register **400** that correspond to the memory addresses where zero weight values are to be written with all zero values. At operation **510**, the weight generator **200** writes a non-zero weight value in the faulty memory address. In some embodiments, the weight value may be supplied as a configuration value (e.g., as the initial weight register value) at the operation **495**. Further, in some embodiments, instead of initializing the first row **405** of the active weight register **400** with the non-zero weight value supplied as an initial weight register value, that non-zero weight value may be added to the row of the active weight register that corresponds to the faulty memory address location. The weight generator **200** may receive the memory address of the faulty memory address location from the address generator **215** via the input **210**. Although the operation **510** is described as being performed after the operation **505**, in some embodiments, the operation **510** may be performed before the operation **505** or both operations may be performed in parallel.

(62) At operation **515**, the BIST circuit **140** receives the output data of the MAC operation from the CIM macro **155**. The operation **515** is similar to the operation **360**. Similarly, operations **520** and **525** are similar to the operations **365** and **370**, respectively, in which the output data is compared with the signature value of the respective cycle, and the result (e.g., match or no match) of the comparison is stored within the register **280**.

(63) At operation **530**, the BIST FSM **170** determines if all the bits of the faulty memory location have been tested. If not, the process **490** loops back to the operation **505** where a different weight value is written to the faulty memory address. For example, in some embodiments, one bit of the weight value from the previous cycle may be varied to generate the weight value for the next cycle. If at the operation **530**, the BIST FSM **170** determines that all cycles are completed, the process **490** proceeds to operation **535**.

(64) Upon completing all cycles, the BIST FSM **170** determines if all (or a threshold number of) cycles have results that match with their respective signature values at the operation **535** and determines whether the faulty memory address passes or fails the BIST. If all the bits of the faulty memory address pass the BIST, then at operation **540**, the CIM macro is considered normal. Otherwise, if at least one bit fails, the CIM macro is considered faulty at operation **545**.

(65) Turning now to FIG. **8**, an example block diagram **550** showing a lossless compression BIST methodology is shown, in accordance with some embodiments of the present disclosure. The block diagram **550** includes an input register **555** configured to store the input vectors (e.g., the output **195**) generated by the data generator **160**. In some embodiments, the input register **555** may be part of the BIST circuit **140**. In other embodiments, the input register **555** may be part of the CIM macro **155**, as shown in FIG. **8**. Thus, in some embodiments, as input vectors are generated by the data generator **160**, those input vectors may be stored in the input register **555** before being applied to the weights to perform the MAC operation. The input vector from the input register **555** for each cycle may be transmitted to a weight and adder tree **560**, as shown by arrow **565**.

(66) The weight and adder tree **560** may be configured to perform the MAC operation on the input vector and the weights. In some embodiments and as discussed above, the CIM macro **155** may be configured such that the memory address space **330** may include a plurality of rows, with each row forming one memory address. In some embodiments, each row of the memory address space **330** may be configured with multiple segments, with each segment including a predefined number of

bits. For example, in some embodiments, each row of the memory address space **330** may be configured in 4 bit segments. Thus, if for example, each row is configured with 256 bits and each segment is 4 bits, each row of the memory address space **330** may include 64 segments. Thus, each of the segments may be part of an “array” including the number of the plurality of rows in the memory address space **330** and one segment. For example, if the memory address space **330** includes 256 rows and each row of 256 bits is divided into segments of 4 bits each, each “array” may be a 256 rows×4 bit array and the CIM macro **155** may include a total of 64 arrays (e.g., 256 bits in a row divided by 4 bits in each segment=64). The 64 arrays are shown in FIG. **8** as arrays **570**.

(67) Although the example above includes 256 rows in the memory address space **330** and 256 bits in each row forming 4-bit segments, in other embodiments, the number of rows in the memory address space may vary. Similarly, the number of bits in each row and the number of bits in each segment may vary from one embodiment to another. Each of the arrays **570** may be configured to perform the MAC operation. Specifically, each of the arrays **570** may be configured to store a plurality of weights in each of the plurality of rows and apply the input vector to the stored plurality of weights. For example and continuing with the example above, a first array **575** of the arrays **570** may be a 256×4 bit array. Each of the 256 rows of the first array **575** may be configured to store a weight value and the input vector may be applied to each of the 256 rows. Thus, the weight and adder tree **560** may be configured to perform the MAC operation using the formula above on the weight values stored in the portion of the CIM macro **155** forming the first array **575** and the input vector being input from the input register **555**.

(68) More particularly, to perform the MAC operation, a product may be computed between the weight value of each row and the input vector. The products from each row may be summed to obtain a partial sum **580**. In some embodiments, in a given cycle, the same input vector may be applied to each row of a particular array. For example and continuing with the example above, in some embodiments, each of the 256 rows in the first array **575** may be applied the same input vector in a given cycle. In other embodiments, at least some of the 256 rows in the first array **575** may be applied different input vectors in the same cycle. Further, in some embodiments, each of the arrays **570** may receive the same input vector(s) in a given cycle. For example, a second array of the arrays **570** may receive the same input vector(s) as the first array **575** in each cycle. In other embodiments, at least some of the arrays may receive different input vector(s) in a particular cycle.

(69) Similarly, in some embodiments, the same weight values may be used in each of the arrays **570** in each cycle. In other embodiments, different weight values may be used in at least some of the arrays **570** in a given cycle. Further, in some embodiments, each of the 256 rows of each of the arrays **570** may store the same weight value in a given cycle. In other embodiments, at least some of the 256 rows of at least some of the arrays **570** may store different weight values in a given cycle. Thus, various combinations of the input vectors and the weight values are contemplated and considered within the scope of the present disclosure. Thus, the weight and adder tree **560** of each of the arrays **570** may perform the MAC operation and generate the partial sum **580**. The partial sum **580** of each of the arrays **570** may be input into a partial sum circuit **585** of that particular array. Thus, although only shown in the first array **575**, each of the arrays **570** may include the partial sum circuit **585**.

(70) The partial sum **580** may be input into an adder/accumulator **590** of the partial sum circuit **585**. The adder/accumulator **590** may be configured to sum the partial sum **580** from each of the cycles of the respective array. Specifically, each cycle may generate the partial sum **580**. The partial sum **580** from each cycle may be summed to generate the output **285**. For example, if the number of cycles is 1000, the adder/accumulator **590** of the first array **575** may add the partial sum **580** from the second cycle to the partial sum from the first cycle to obtain a first accumulated sum, then sum the partial result from the third cycle to the first accumulated sum to obtain a second accumulated sum, sum the partial result from the fourth cycle to the second accumulated sum, and so on until

the partial sums from all the 1000 cycles have been added to generate a single output (e.g., the output **285**) after the 1000.sup.th cycle. Although 1000 cycles are used, the number of cycles may vary from one embodiment to another.

(71) After each cycle, the adder/accumulator **590** may send the first accumulated sum, the second accumulated sum, and so on to a register **595** for temporary storing. The register **595** may send that received value back as a latest accumulated sum **600** to the adder/accumulator **590** for being added to the partial sum **580** from the next cycle. In some embodiments, the sum of the latest accumulated sum **600** from the register **595** and the partial sum **580** from the weight and adder tree **560** may generate a carry over value. The carry over value may be output from the adder/accumulator **590** as a carryout value **605**. In some embodiments, the carryout value **605** may be stored in a register **610** and provided to a multiplexer **615**. Thus, in each cycle, as the adder/accumulator **590** sums the latest accumulated sum **600** and the partial sum **580**, the adder/accumulator may generate the carryout value **605**. In some embodiments, no carryout value may be generated. In such cases, the carryout value **605** may be zero.

(72) The register **610** and the multiplexer **615** may form a carry rotation circuit to send the carryout value from a previous cycle back to the adder/accumulator **590** for summing in the next cycle. For example, the carryout value **605** generated in a first cycle may be recycled back to the adder/accumulator **590** for summing in a second cycle. Thus, in each cycle, the adder/accumulator **590** computes a sum between the latest accumulated sum **600**, the partial sum **580**, and the carryout value **605** from the previous cycle. Without accounting for the carryout value **605**, the final output (e.g., the output **285**) may be incorrect and lead to signature aliasing. Thus, by rotating the carryout value **605** back into the adder/accumulator **590**, the adder/accumulator ensures that the sums are correctly computed by accounting for the carry out values, thereby avoiding signature aliasing and achieving a “lossless compression.” “Lossless compression” as used herein means that the partial sum **580** of each of the cycles is combined together or compressed into a single final output (e.g., the final output **285**) while accounting for the carryout value **605**. Specifically, by virtue of rotating the carryout value **605**, any data that may have been lost due to not accounting the carryout value is now accounted for, resulting in a lossless compression.

(73) The multiplexer **615** may also receive an input **620**. In some embodiments, the input **620** may be set to zero and may be used during a functional operation (e.g., normal operation) of the CIM macro **155**. The operation of the multiplexer **615** may be controlled by the enable signal **190** generated by the BIST circuit **140**. If the enable signal **190** indicates a BIST mode, the multiplexer **615** selects the carryout value **605** as a carry-in (CIN) value **625**. If the enable signal **190** indicates a functional mode, the multiplexer **615** selects the input **620** as the carry-in value **625**, which is fed back into the adder/accumulator **590**.

(74) Upon the completion of all cycles, the final output from the adder/accumulator **590** is transmitted as the output **285** for comparison with the signature value(s). Although not shown, each of the input register **555**, the weight & adder tree **560**, the adder/accumulator **590**, the register **595**, the register **610**, and the multiplexer **615** may be configured as hardware, software, firmware, or a combination thereof.

(75) Referring now to FIG. **9**, an example flowchart outlining operation of a process **630** is shown, in accordance with some embodiments of the present disclosure. The process **630** may be used to implement a lossless compression BIST methodology by the CIM macro **155** and the BIST circuit **140**. The process **630** begins at the operation **635** with each of the arrays **570** receiving the input vector(s) generated by the data generator **160**. Specifically, before the performance of the process **630**, the BIST circuit **140** may be initialized by writing configuration values in the configuration register **265**. For example, in some embodiments, the configuration values may include the weight value(s) (or at least the initial weight register value) for each cycle for each of the arrays **570**, the number of cycles, signature value for each of the arrays, data pattern(s) for each cycle for each of the arrays, and any other information that may be needed or considered desirable. At the operation

635, each of the arrays **570**, and particularly, the weight and adder tree **560** of each of those arrays receives the input vector(s) from the input register **555**. The input vector(s) are generated by the data generator **160** of the BIST circuit **140** and stored into the input register **555**. At operation **640**, each of the arrays **570**, and particularly the weight and adder tree **560** of each of those arrays receives the weight value(s) generated by the weight generator **200** as discussed above.

(76) At operation **645**, the weight and adder tree **560** of each of the arrays **570** computes the partial sum **580** by performing a MAC operation based on the input vector of the operation **635** and the weight values of the operation **640**. The weight and adder tree **560** of each of the arrays **570** transmits the partial sum **580** to the adder/accumulator **590** of the respective arrays at operation **650**. At operation **655**, the adder/accumulator **590** of each of the arrays **570** receives and computes a sum between the latest accumulated sum from the register **595** corresponding to the sums of all the partial sums from all previous cycles, the carry-in value **625** corresponding to the carryout value **605** from the immediately previous cycle, and the partial sum **580** from the weight and adder tree **560** of the current cycle to generate a latest accumulated sum. The latest accumulated sum is stored within the register **595** at operation **660** and transmitted back to the adder/accumulator for computation in the next cycle. Also, at operation **665**, the carryout value **605** from the current cycle is fed back to the adder/accumulator **590** via the multiplexer **615**. The operations **660** and **665** may occur in parallel or the operation **665** may occur before the operation **660**.

(77) At operation **670**, the CIM macro **155** or the BIST FSM **170** determines if additional cycles are remaining. In some embodiments, the CIM macro **155** may determine that the current cycle is the last cycle if no new input vector(s) and/or weight value(s) are received by the weight and adder tree **560**. In other embodiments, the CIM macro **155** may identify the last cycle in other ways. If at the operation **670**, it is determined that additional cycles are pending, the process **630** loops back to the operation **635** for receiving new input vector(s). In some embodiments, only the weight values may change from one cycle to the next. In such cases, the process **630** may loop back to the operation **640** instead. Further, in some embodiments in which new input vector(s) are provided, same weight value(s) may be used. In such cases, the operation **640** may be skipped.

(78) If at the operation **670**, it is determined that the current cycle is the last cycle, the process **630** proceeds to operation **675** where the final latest accumulated sum from the adder/accumulator **590** is sent out as the output **285** to the BIST circuit **140**. In some embodiments, the adder/accumulator **590** may also send out the latest accumulated sum from each cycle to the BIST circuit **140**. The BIST circuit **140** may either ignore such intermediate latest accumulated sum values or store the intermediate latest accumulated sum values. The final latest accumulated sum may be used by the BIST circuit **140** to determine whether the CIM macro **155** is normal or faulty. Thus, operations **680-690** may be performed by the BIST circuit **140**. Thus, at the operation **675**, the BIST circuit **140** may receive the final latest accumulated sum from each of the arrays **570**. At the operation **680**, the BIST circuit **140** compares the received final latest accumulated sum from each of the arrays **570** with the expected signature value(s). If all (or a predetermined number of) the final latest accumulated sums from the arrays **570** match their respective signature value(s), the CIM macro **155** is declared to be normal at the operation **685**. If at least one (or a predetermined number of) of the final latest accumulated sum does not match the respective signature value, the CIM macro **155** is declared to be faulty at operation **690**.

(79) Thus, the present disclosure provides an easy, effective, and accurate method for performing BIST on a CIM macro. The BIST methodologies of the present disclosure may be used without needing to modify an existing CIM macro. The BIST methodologies disclosed herein provide a high-test coverage solution by using deterministic signed weights, random or deterministic input vectors, signed or unsigned values, and using the MAC operations to test the CIM macro without needing any specialized simulations. The BIST methodologies may be used to test the CIM macro over a wide range of input vectors and weight values. The BIST methodologies of the present disclosure are highly configurable, provide easier fault diagnostics, and provide deterministic

results that lead to better resolution between normal and faulty CIM macros. The BIST methodologies of the present disclosure also provide high test coverage at high speed and short test time. For example, tests that the inventors conducted using 8 deterministic weights and 1000 pseudorandom input vectors resulted in about 99% test coverage of the CIM macro in about 15 microseconds at 1 Giga Hertz.

(80) In accordance with some aspects of the present disclosure, a method is disclosed. The method includes generating, by a built-in self-test circuit, a plurality of input vectors for transmission to a memory macro for testing the memory macro. At least one input vector of the plurality of input vectors is transmitted to the memory macro in each of a plurality of cycles. The method also includes receiving, by the built-in self-test circuit, in each of the plurality of cycles, an output data from the memory macro, such that the output data is generated by the memory macro in response to processing the at least one input vector, comparing, by the built-in self-test circuit, the output data in each of the plurality of cycles with a signature value, and determining, by the built-in self-test circuit, whether the memory macro is normal or faulty based upon the comparison.

(81) In accordance with some other aspects of the present disclosure, another method is disclosed. The method includes generating, by a built-in self-test circuit, a plurality of weight values in a plurality of cycles for writing to a memory macro for testing the memory macro, such that generating the plurality of weight values in each of the plurality of cycles includes receiving, by the built-in self-test circuit, an initial weight register value, receiving, by the built-in self-test circuit, an increment value, initializing, by the built-in self-test circuit, an active weight register value with the initial weight register value to obtain a first weight value of the plurality of weight values, and incrementing, by the built-in self-test circuit, the active weight register value as a function of a previous active weight register value and the increment value to obtain additional weight values of the plurality of weight values. The method also includes receiving, by the built-in self-test circuit, in each of the plurality of cycles, an output data from the memory macro, such that the output data of each of the plurality of cycles is generated by the memory macro in response to processing an input vector and the plurality of weight values, comparing, by the built-in self-test circuit, the output data in each of the plurality of cycles with a signature value associated with a respective one of the plurality of cycles, and determining, by the built-in self-test circuit, whether the memory macro is normal or faulty based upon the comparison.

(82) In accordance with yet other aspects of the present disclosure, a built-in self-test circuit is disclosed. The built-in self-test circuit includes a memory having computer-readable instructions stored thereon and a processor that executes the computer-readable instructions to generate and transmit a plurality of input vectors in a plurality of cycles to a plurality of arrays of a memory macro for testing the memory macro, such that at least one input vector of the plurality of input vectors is transmitted to each of the plurality of arrays in each of the plurality of cycles, generate and transmit a plurality of weights for writing to each of the plurality of arrays of the memory macro in each of the plurality of cycles, and receive a final sum value from each of the plurality of arrays of the memory macro, such that the final sum from each of the plurality of arrays corresponds to a computation performed in each of the plurality of arrays over the plurality of cycles. The processor further executes the computer-readable instructions to compare the final sum value from each of the plurality of arrays with an expected signature value, and determine that the memory macro is normal based upon the final sum value from each of the plurality of arrays matching the expected signature value.

(83) The foregoing outlines features of several embodiments so that those skilled in the art may better understand the aspects of the present disclosure. Those skilled in the art should appreciate that they may readily use the present disclosure as a basis for designing or modifying other processes and structures for carrying out the same purposes and/or achieving the same advantages of the embodiments introduced herein. Those skilled in the art should also realize that such equivalent constructions do not depart from the spirit and scope of the present disclosure, and that

they may make various changes, substitutions, and alterations herein without departing from the spirit and scope of the present disclosure.

Claims

1. A method comprising: generating, by a built-in self-test circuit, a plurality of input vectors for transmission to a memory macro for testing the memory macro, wherein at least one input vector of the plurality of input vectors is transmitted to the memory macro in each of a plurality of cycles; receiving, by the built-in self-test circuit, in each of the plurality of cycles, an output data from the memory macro, wherein the output data is generated by the memory macro in response to processing the at least one input vector; comparing, by the built-in self-test circuit, the output data in each of the plurality of cycles with a signature value; and determining, by the built-in self-test circuit, that the memory macro is normal based on the output data matching the signature value in each of the plurality of cycles or faulty based on the output data not matching the signature value in at least one of the plurality of cycles.
2. The method of claim 1, wherein the at least one input vector is random, pseudorandom, or deterministic.
3. The method of claim 1, wherein the at least one input vector is signed or unsigned.
4. The method of claim 1, wherein the memory macro is a compute in memory macro.
5. The method of claim 1, further comprising writing, by the built-in self-test circuit, a plurality of weight values in the memory macro in each of the plurality of cycles, wherein the processing of the at least one input vector in each of the plurality of cycles comprises performing a multiply-and-accumulate operation between the plurality of weight values and the at least one input vector.
6. The method of claim 5, wherein each of the plurality of weight values comprises a signed value or an unsigned value.
7. The method of claim 5, further comprising: generating, by the built-in self-test circuit, a weight value of the plurality of weight values by: receiving, by the built-in self-test circuit, an initial weight register value; and initializing, by the built-in self-test circuit, an active weight register value with the initial weight register value to obtain the weight value.
8. The method of claim 1, wherein a number of the plurality of cycles is greater than a number of cycles used during a functional operation of the memory macro.
9. The method of claim 1, wherein the plurality of input vectors comprises a different input vector in each of the plurality of cycles, and wherein each of the different input vector is associated with a different signature value for comparison with the output data.
10. The method of claim 1, wherein a same input vector is used in each of the plurality of cycles.
11. The method of claim 1, wherein the input vector that is used in at least some of the plurality of cycles is different from the input vector that is used in other ones of the plurality of cycles.
12. A built-in self-test circuit comprising: a memory having computer-readable instructions stored thereon; and a processor that executes the computer-readable instructions to: generate and write a plurality of weight values in a plurality of cycles to a memory macro for testing the memory macro; generate and transmit a plurality of input vectors to the memory macro, wherein at least one input vector of the plurality of input vectors is transmitted to the memory macro in each of a plurality of cycles, and wherein a number of the plurality of cycles is greater than a number of cycles used during a functional operation of the memory macro; receive in each of the plurality of cycles, an output data from the memory macro, wherein the output data of each of the plurality of cycles is generated by the memory macro in response to processing the at least one input vector and at least one weight value of the plurality of weight values; and determine whether the memory macro is normal or faulty based upon a comparison of the output data in each of the plurality of cycles with a signature value associated with a respective one of the plurality of cycles.
13. The built-in self-test circuit of claim 12, wherein to generate the plurality of weight values in

each of the plurality of cycles, the processor further executes computer-readable instructions to: receive an initial weight register value; receive an increment value; initialize an active weight register value with the initial weight register value to obtain a first weight value of the plurality of weight values; and increment the active weight register value as a function of a previous active weight register value and the increment value to obtain additional weight values of the plurality of weight values.

14. The built-in self-test circuit of claim 12, wherein the at least one input vector is random, pseudorandom, or deterministic.

15. The built-in self-test circuit of claim 12, wherein the at least one input vector is signed or unsigned.

16. The built-in self-test circuit of claim 12, wherein the processor further executes computer-readable instructions to: determine that the memory macro is normal based on the output data matching the signature value in each of the plurality of cycles; or determine that the memory macro is faulty based on the output data not matching the signature value in at least one of the plurality of cycles.

17. The built-in self-test circuit of claim 12, wherein each of the plurality of weight values comprises a signed value or an unsigned value.

18. A method comprising: generating and transmitting, by a built-in self-test circuit, a plurality of input vectors in a plurality of cycles to a plurality of arrays of a memory macro for testing the memory macro; generating and transmitting, by the built-in self-test circuit, a plurality of weight values for writing to each of the plurality of arrays of the memory macro in each of the plurality of cycles; receiving, by the built-in self-test circuit, a final sum value from each of the plurality of arrays of the memory macro over the plurality of cycles; and determining, by the built-in self-test circuit, whether the memory macro is normal or faulty based on a comparison of the final sum value from each of the plurality of arrays with an expected signature value.

19. The method of claim 18, wherein generating, by the built-in self-test circuit, a weight value of the plurality of weight values comprises: receiving, by the built-in self-test circuit, an initial weight register value; and initializing, by the built-in self-test circuit, an active weight register value with the initial weight register value to obtain the weight value.

20. The method of claim 18, wherein a number of the plurality of cycles is greater than a number of cycles used during a functional operation of the memory macro.
